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Pine Siskin

Spinus pinus

QUICK STATS

Length	4.3 – 5.5 in (11 – 14 cm)
Wingspan	7.1 – 8.7 in (18 – 22 cm)
Weight	0.4 – 0.6 oz (12 – 18 g)
Lifespan	Up to 9 years (avg. 2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Pine Siskin is a small, heavily streaked finch of the boreal and montane forests — an irruptive winter visitor whose appearances at feeders are excitingly unpredictable. In years when conifer seed crops fail across the North, Pine Siskins erupt southward in enormous numbers, descending on nyjer feeders and birch trees across the continent. In other years they are virtually absent. The subtle yellow flash in the wings and at the base of the tail is the key field mark that separates this species from other streaked finches. Despite its plain appearance, the Pine Siskin is a remarkably hardy bird, capable of surviving temperatures as low as -94°F (-70°C) by raising its metabolic rate.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Pine Siskin breeds across the boreal forests of Canada and Alaska, and in montane conifer forests south through the Rockies, Cascades, and Sierra Nevada into Mexico. In winter it moves south and east in variable numbers, potentially appearing anywhere in the contiguous United States during irruption years. It inhabits coniferous and mixed forests, forest edges, weedy fields, and alder and birch stands. In irruption years it frequently visits nyjer feeders in suburban gardens far outside its normal range.

DIET & FEEDING

- Nyjer (thistle) seed — the top feeder choice, attracts large flocks
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and sunflower chips
- Conifer seeds extracted from open cones — the core wild food
- Alder and birch catkin seeds in late winter
- Weed seeds: thistle, dandelion, ragweed
- Salt and mineral deposits — regularly visits salt licks and road salt

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Pine Siskins are intensely gregarious, almost always found in flocks — sometimes mixed with American Goldfinches, Common Redpolls, and other small finches. They are acrobatic feeders, clinging to the tips of conifer branches and hanging upside-down from seed heads with ease. At feeders they can be surprisingly aggressive for their size, using a threatening wing-spread display to dominate larger birds. During irruption years they may appear at feeders by the dozen or even the hundred. They have a remarkable ability to cache seeds and to increase their food intake dramatically before cold nights.

NESTING & BREEDING

Pine Siskins breed in loose colonies in coniferous forests. The female builds a well-concealed shallow cup nest of twigs, grass, and rootlets on a horizontal conifer branch, lined with fur, feathers, and plant down. Clutches of 3–5 pale blue-green eggs with dark spots are incubated by the female for 13 days, while the male feeds her. Both parents feed the nestlings regurgitated seeds. Young fledge at 14–15 days. Pairs raise 1–2 broods per season, with breeding timed to conifer seed availability.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Pine Siskin's calls are highly distinctive — a rising, buzzy "zreeeee" or "skreee" that is unlike any other small finch and carries a characteristic ascending quality. Flocks produce a constant chatter of these calls and short musical twitters. The song is a rambling series of musical and buzzy phrases, similar to an American Goldfinch but harsher and more variable.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
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The Pine Siskin population is estimated at 35 million individuals but has declined significantly — by roughly 80% — since 1970, making it one of the most steeply declining songbirds in North America. Loss of boreal forest, changes in conifer seed production linked to climate change, and Salmonella outbreaks at contaminated feeders are the primary threats. Keeping nyjer feeders scrupulously clean is critical during irruption years.

FEEDER TIPS

- Stock nyjer feeders before November — irruptions can arrive suddenly
- Clean nyjer feeders weekly — Pine Siskins are highly susceptible to Salmonella
- A thistle sock or fine-mesh nyjer tube is ideal; they cling well
- In irruption years, expect them to arrive with American Goldfinch flocks
- Check wing and tail bases for yellow flash — the key ID mark in mixed flocks

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Overall body	Brown, heavily streaked dark
Yellow wing flash	Pale yellow — base of flight feathers
Yellow tail base	Yellow at base of tail — both sexes
Crown	Dark brown with fine streaking
Underparts	Whitish, streaked brown
Bill	Short, sharply pointed, dark

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